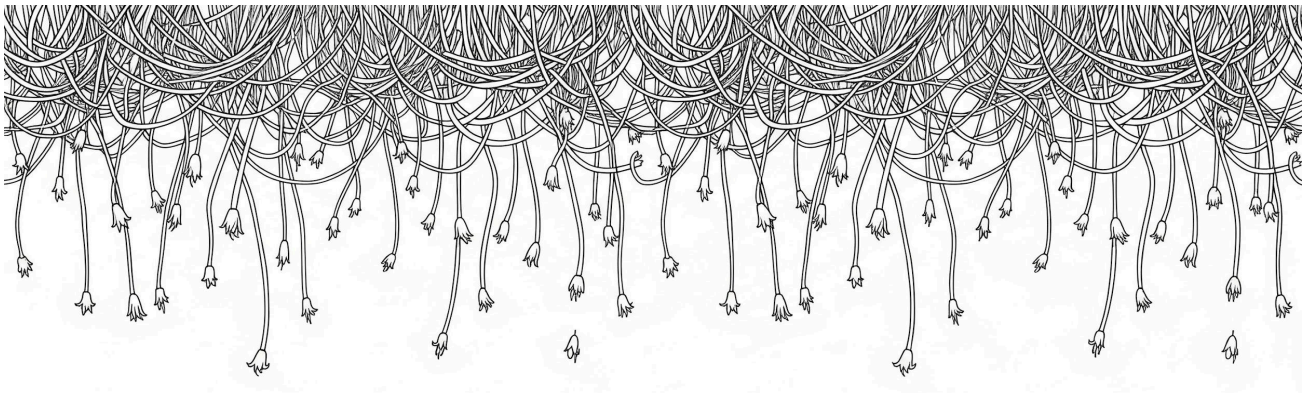


The Curious Case Of Seraphina Moon

Let it be known to all, then, that Anteros Magnus harboured a distinct—and quite unconcealed—aversion to Seraphina Moon, a young lady possessed of hair in an unusual shade of silver, a tongue sharp as any dagger, and a most unfortunate conviction in her own singular superiority amongst the scholars of the Sartryx.

It was widely proclaimed that Seraphina Moon was the very paragon of students—a creature of such scholastic brilliance that professors did lavish her with praise most fulsome, and greet her every endeavour with applause akin to hymns sung in church. Yet while she bestowed smiles of surpassing sweetness upon those august personages who stood behind the master's desk, she would cast upon the common folk of the school—those she deemed her inferiors—a look of such haughtiness and disdain as might chill even the warmest of hearts.

Alas, it befell poor Anteros Magnus to find himself seated beside Seraphina Moon in History class—a circumstance which, by ill fortune, stretched to the full and harrowing span of three hours. To be the desk companion of the infamous Moon, as she was known, was to endure the keenest of cold gazes and the promptest of responses—none of them agreeable. Indeed, it was a predicament not of his own devising; for had he any liberty of choice, he would have gladly taken his place beside Tirian Kallan, a dear friend of ten years' standing—and one who, truth be told, held no small sway over his heart.

'Twas Professor Callaghn, a man of some fifty years and possessed of an air most assured, who deemed the selection of one's own place in History class a folly most grievous. Wherefore, with the flourish of one accustomed to command, he did inscribed upon the blackboard—his handwriting as neat as any scrivener's—the names *Seraphina Moon*, *Anteros Magnus* beneath the bold heading *Desk Twelve*, leaving no room for debate nor footnote of appeal, as if by ancient decree—binding them as surely as any Oraisayn's decision.

"Mr. Magnus," said Seraphina Moon, bowing with delicate yet frigid formality. The air seemed to cool around her, matching her glacial tone and distant demeanour. Though her posture was reverent, her every motion exuded the polite contempt of a Clothi raised on etiquette and quiet judgment.

"It is most unfortunate to be paired with you. However, given Professor Callaghn's remarkable stubbornness, I suspect we have no choice but to conduct our research on *Fate and Threads* together."

"I suppose."

"What days are you free, may I ask?"

"Thursdays."

"Only Thursdays?"

"Just Thursdays."

"…How otiose."

"Otiose?"

Verily, Seraphina Moon would employ such a word with the ease of one addressing a lifelong companion, when in truth, they scarcely shared an acquaintance and were, indeed, nigh to utter strangers. A most perplexing—and, some might venture, impertinent—choice of phrase.

Otiose.

Anteros found himself grasping for a rejoinder. A murmur. A trifling expression of resistance. Yet, subjected as he was to Miss Moon's luminous (if

undeniably glacial) gaze, it occurred to him that even the flutter of an eyelid might be interpreted as a declaration of dissent.

"…Er. Thursdays and Fridays?"

Seraphina hummed.

Not a word. Not a nod. Just a hum—delicate, noncommittal, and wholly triumphant.

Thus ended their illicit exchange for the duration of History class, and Anteros, with a most deliberate pace, betook himself towards Tirian Kallan, whose very hair seemed to catch and hold the September sunbeams, radiating a warmth that echoed the responsive flicker in his own heart. It was as if, in Tirian's presence, the very air hummed with a subtle magic, a counterpoint to the icy stillness Seraphina Moon seemed to carry with her always, like a winter sprite forever unthawed.

"You seem bothered," Tirian—with the air of ease and coolness—greeted Anteros, a most casual hand reaching out to his tie, adjusting the knot with an almost imperceptible flick of the wrist, the assured motion of one who had known him these thirteen years, "Did the Ice Queen bestow some chilling pronouncement? Did Miss Moon, that most formidable of scholars, engage you in verbal jousting? I observed her lips in motion—a truly remarkable event, one might add, since it is generally only the esteemed Professors who are granted the favour of her conversation."

Seraphina Moon did not, by any measure, enjoy a favourable rapport with her fellow students—so much so that even Tirian Kallan, who was known to befriend the school's strangest and shyest souls, had her share of well-formed opinions where Miss Moon was concerned.

Thus resumed their most familiar pastime: the analysis and occasional dissection of Seraphina Moon.

"She said *otiose*. Can you believe that?"

"*Otiose*?"

“Yes!”

Tirian grinned. “Well, at least she’s gracious enough to insult people in high diction. Most girls just roll their eyes.”

And so they did—especially when one hailed from Clothos, the region where blood runs laced with gold and threads are spun with destiny itself. Seraphina Moon was the only daughter of Duke Ishaan Moon, a weaver of considerable renown and the sole proprietor of Moon Threads, whose exports clothed half the realm and lined the coffers of the Sartryx themselves.

His wife, it was said, hailed from Iluyto—a land of fire and heat—and though her name was rarely uttered in court, whispers persisted. Some claimed her grandfather was a Kaabaig, though such a suggestion was considered deeply disrespectful. Kaabaigs, after all, were creatures of ancient myth and sacred forest, rarely seen outside of Kaia in modern times. To imply that such blood ran through a Clothos noble line was not merely gossip—it was *heresy stitched in silk*.

At least, Anteros begrudgingly agreed, Seraphina Moon wasn’t *that* bad—certainly not in comparison to most Clothi girls.

Yes, she exuded delusions of grandeur. Yes, her mouth dispensed words like poison ivy—graceful in form, caustic in effect. But that, he reasoned, was mere surmise. And honestly? A far better alternative to someone *querulous and nettlesome*.

Anteros was nothing if not fair. And fair-minded scholars, of course, give credit where it was due.

Enter Reve Sagan, burnt-orange hair gleaming, arms laden with drama and debt.

“Are you two *still* talking about Seraphina Moon?” he drawled, “Honestly, for people who claim to dislike her, you behave quite the opposite.”

“Shut up, Reve,” Tirian said, blowing a raspberry.

“You owe me thirty pearls from last time!”

“Oh threads, Kallan—that was a year ago!”

“You still lost, Sagan. Thirty pearls is thirty pearls.”

Reve Sagan groaned in theatrical dismay, patting his coat as if the pearls might miraculously appear from the folds. With a final huff, he fished them out—reluctantly handing over the glittering currency he’d lost to Tirian after the Sartryx’s annual Weaveflight, in which the Ilustras had claimed victory.

“Magnus, you better control your girl before she milks the first-years dry.”

“She isn’t—!” Anteros snapped, red-faced.

Tirian only grinned, entirely unhelpful.

“Whatever.” Reve rolled his eyes with all the dramatic indifference of someone who *absolutely cared but would die before admitting it*.

“Anyway. What is it this time about Seraphina Moon?”

“Well, Icy Moon just called our lovely Anteros *otiose*!”

“For real? She called me a *bollix* once. Interrupted a first-year’s Weaveflight drill by accident,” Reve said, rubbing the back of his neck with a sheepish grimace. “I hardly think yours is worse.”

“…At least that one’s reasonable,” Anteros muttered.

“Hey, I’ll have you know—they were already two hours in!”

“Practice rounds are usually three, Reve.” Tirian said, raising a brow.

“Oh.”

Reve went quiet for a moment.

“Well, she *still* called me ‘bollix’—which isn’t exactly polite, mind you.”

“When was she ever polite?” Tirian deadpanned.

The three of us went silent.

“…At least she’s pretty,” Reve offered noncommittally.

Tirian smacked him on the arm.

“What? Don’t tell me you’re a part of the *Moonies*!?”

“The what now?” Anteros blinked.

“Seraphina’s fans,” Tirian explained, wrinkling her nose.

“She has fans?” he asked, scandalized.

“Oh, come on, Anteros—don’t be a liar.”

Reve clicked his tongue, then casually slung an arm over his shoulder.

“Seraphina Moon is *pretty*. Silver hair, skin akin to a moon thread, and eyes like royalty. The girl practically glows. If she told me to study advanced threadwork barefoot in a thunderstorm, I might consider it.”

It must be conceded, however reluctantly by Anteros Magnus, that Seraphina Moon possessed a degree of comeliness not easily overlooked. A beauty, indeed, of a sort that might inspire admiration, even amongst those inclined to be critical of her general deportment. Her father, as the so-called "Moonlight Duke" according to the Fatum Express, lent her a reflected glory, yet her own countenance, it was undeniably evident, shone with a similar lustre. One could not but acknowledge her as a belle, though whether this acknowledgment ought to extend to a deeper approbation was a question that gave Anteros no little disquiet.

Reve, uncouth as he is, notices Anteros moment of hesitation and thereby concluded the most outrageous statement that ever came out of his mouth;

“Silence means yes, Magnus.” Reve smirked, self-satisfaction curling on his face like a cat in the sun. “It is plain to see that you, too, find Seraphina's charms not entirely negligible.”

“I do not.” Anteros interjected with such vehemence that his voice cracked at the end, pushing Reve’s arm from his shoulder as though it were some offending barnacle. “Her? Pretty? I would rather push myself off of the Sartryx.”

Reve only snorted. “Well, then by all means, Magnus—do take the leap. But I daresay, even mid-air, you’d find a way to compare her eyelashes to the curvature of the moon.”

“I would rather die.”

Tirian chuckled—just barely. The sound faltered before it could fully form. She adjusted the cuff of her sleeve, eyes flicking elsewhere.

Reve noticed, of course. He always did. But for once, he said nothing.

With a huff, Anteros turned away from Reve and Tirian, marching with exaggerated purpose towards the nearest bookshelf. He feigned interest in the spines of dusty tomes, though his mind raced with the impossible suggestion that he harbored any admiration for Seraphina Moon beyond an acknowledgment of her superficial beauty. Nonsense! Utter hogwash! He'd rather take his chance in Laywakilab than admit such a ridiculous notion.

Yet, even as he tried to summon up his most potent distaste for Seraphina, his mind betrayed him with inconvenient details. The way her silver hair caught the light, sometimes shimmering like spun moonlight. The sharp, intelligent glint in her eyes, even when she was delivering the most biting of pronouncements. And, yes, fine, perhaps there was a certain grace to her movements—a regal quality that spoke of her noble lineage, not that Anteros cared a whit about such things.

“Found anything interesting?” Tirian’s voice came from behind, light and measured.

Anteros startled—just a little—and ran a finger over the spine of a book he wasn’t really seeing. *An Illustrated Index of Thread Variance in Eastern Provinces*. Fascinating. Riveting.

“Just hiding from your taunts,” he said dryly. “And the Moonies.”

“You started that one yourself,” she replied, stepping into the row beside him. Her lips remained a line, unreadable.

There was a silence—not an awkward one, but the kind that hangs in the air like something unspoken waiting to be tied.

"…You don't really think she's pretty, do you?" Tirian asked, eyes fixed on the row ahead.

Anteros froze. A breath caught in his chest. The question was simple. Her tone even. But he knew Tirian too well—and the thread beneath the words was anything but casual.

"…I think," he said carefully, "that Seraphina Moon is… infuriating. And arrogant. And unreasonably smug."

Tirian didn't answer. Her silence twisted inside him more than any sharp retort would have.

He turned, almost defensively. "She's just… polished. That's all. Like a marble statue. Cold. Beautiful, maybe. But lifeless."

Tirian gave a small nod.

Reve seemed to sense something amiss. His brows lifted, then drew together with sudden, performative interest. "Hey," he said, tone casual but a little too bright, "there seems to be a commotion at the courtyard. How about we check it out?"

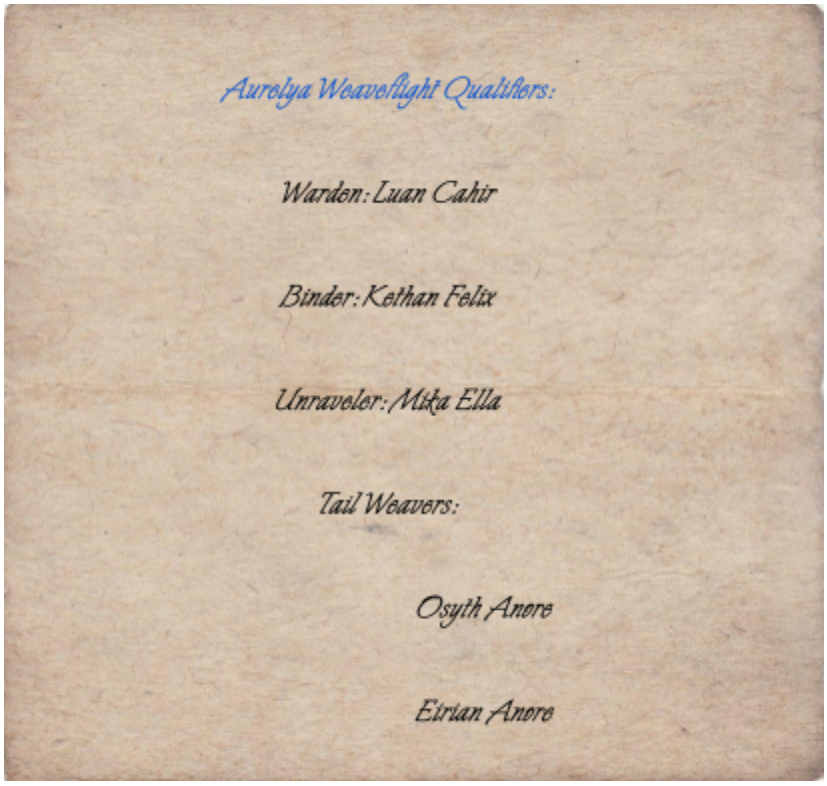
"Right," Tirian replied, latching onto the distraction like a lifeline. "Aren't they going to post the qualifiers for this month's Weaveflight?"

Anteros, grateful for any subject not involving silver-haired girls and his opinion of them, nodded stiffly. "Let's go."

The Sartryx's courtyard was full of lively chatter as the crowd gathered around the Oraisayn, in front of it was a board filled with this year's qualifiers and whose house was in the current lead of the Weaveflight. The courtyard of the Sartryx, a place oft frequented by scholars and those of leisure, was at this hour a scene of considerable animation. A throng had assembled, drawn together by the prospect of news, their voices mingling in a lively murmur, not unlike the buzzing of bees about a hive. For there, before them, stood the esteemed Oraisayn, and affixed to a board was a catalogue of no small consequence—the names of those deemed

qualified for this year's Weaveflight, as well as an accounting of which house held present ascendancy in that spirited competition.

"Bloody threads," Tirian muttered, her eyes tracing the roster for Aurelya. It was indeed displayed for all to see, the list of those deemed fit for the Weaveflight—a matter of no small importance in their little world.

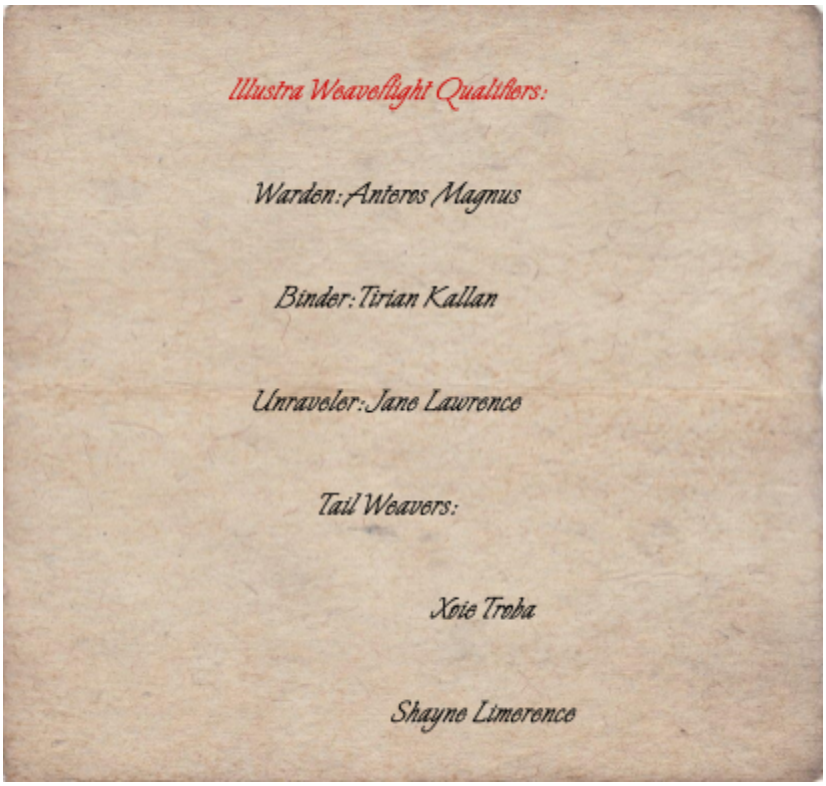


And then, at the very nadir of the document, as if placed there with a touch of deliberate irony, or perhaps even spite, the name appeared:

One could not but observe, with a certain degree of piqued amusement, the order of things. To be a Tail Weaver, while respectable, was hardly akin to managing the whole affair. Yet there was Seraphina, perched atop, not weaving or unraveling, but *managing*. It did speak volumes, did it not? Some might argue that such a position required an organizational prowess quite beyond the reach of mere weavers, a mind for strategy and a knowledge of threads both literal and metaphorical. Others, of a less generous disposition, might merely raise an eyebrow and murmur of connections, and fathers in high places.

"What does Seraphina Moon know about Weaveflight?" Tirian pronounced to Reve, her tone thick with incredulity, her brow furrowed in profound bemusement. She watched him pore over Aurelya's roster, scrutinizing it repeatedly as though the very parchment were a figment of his imagination, his actions only heightening her bafflement.

"Apparently enough to make her manager," Reve replied dryly, his eyes flitting from Therenynox's list to Illustra's. "And speaking of—looks like both of you made it in again. Captain and Co-Captain."



Anteros snorted. “Afraid you’ll lose thirty pearls again, Sagan?”

“Come on, man! Enough with the pearls!” Reve groaned, dramatically as ever. “You Illustra are savages on the field. Us poor Velquinns just prayed you’d all catch the flu.”

It is a truth universally acknowledged, that a house long accustomed to victory in the Weaveflight tournaments must be the subject of a certain envy from those less fortunate, their triumphs having invariably secured for them the coveted Loom Thread with annual regularity. Naturally, every Weaveflight was the epitome of conquering Illustra’s place in the tournament, and thus, their natural enemy for such is the House of Aurelya—who houses of the most noblest and renowned names of Fatum—wants the slice of success.

A hush descended upon the Sartryx’s courtyard, the air itself seeming to cool at the entrance of Seraphina Moon. Her silvery hair, reminiscent of the finest Moonthread, marked her passage as she approached the notice board. Erect and composed, her coiffure impeccable, her gaze held a detached iciness that drew the

immediate, if hushed, attention of the assembled students, their murmurs a collective acknowledgment of her formidable and glacial presence.

Reve, bless his uncouth heart, hailed Seraphina as if they were intimates of long standing, a boisterous "Yo, Moon!" cutting through the hushed reverence her arrival typically commanded.

"Reve!" Tirian exclaimed, accompanying her sharp address with a sharper swat to his arm. The burnt-orange menace, however, was not so easily deterred, and despite the physical reprimand, maintained his cheerful, if ill-timed, salutation. Ultimately, with a slow and deliberate grace that spoke volumes of her self-possession, Seraphina Moon inclined her head in acknowledgment.

“Mr. Sagan,” she offered, a bow of exquisite formality, “Ms. Kallan, and Mr. Magnus. It appears our paths have converged once more.”

“Sera,” Reve declared with an air of utmost familiarity, an appellation that caused the faintest ripple of displeasure to cross Miss Moon’s otherwise serene countenance, a detail not lost upon Anteros. “How truly delightful to find you gracing the Weaveflight with your presence this year! One had not imagined the esteemed Moon family held such…enthusiasm for these proceedings.”

“I secured this management role solely due to Ms. Hurtafilla’s absence during the Weaveflight,” Miss Moon stated, her tone betraying a certain impatience, a distinct air of superiority clinging to her words. “Though it was scarcely my ambition to oversee Aurelya’s endeavors in the Weaveflight, it might indeed prove a timely occasion for the Illustras to forfeit a Loom Thread.”

As if Anteros Magnus would sooner forfeit his own prospects entirely than permit Seraphina Moon to acquire such a prize as the Loom Thread.

And Tirian's slow step past Reve—marked by an all-too-composed smile and the measured flick of her braid over one shoulder—suggested a similar sentiment no less intense.

"Is Miss Moon truly suggesting that *Aurelya* shall triumph over *Illustra* this year?" Anteros could sense the unspoken 'Ridiculous' beneath Tirian's practical tone. "Illustra, who have enjoyed victory for three consecutive years?"

Seraphina Moon, visibly annoyed by Tirian's question, crossed her arms and retorted, "Is it wrong to hope my house wins?" she replied evenly. "Illustra may have dominated for the past three years, but Aurelya was the tournament champion before that."

A beat. Then two.

Tirian's shoulder stiffened. Her jaw twitched.

It was subtle—but not to Anteros. And certainly not Reve, who leaned back as if preparing for impact.

Anteros, ever the reluctant mediator (and painfully aware of the heat building up between the two girls), stepped in. "Miss Moon," he said, careful to coat his voice with civility, "It would be wise not to speak in such terms. Your words may be… misconstructed as mockery of Illustra's victories."

Seraphina blinked.

Just once.

Then her brow softened. Her arms loosened.

"Oh," she murmured, before clarifying, "That wasn't my intention."

And with nothing more than a graceful pivot, she departed—moonthread ribbons trailing like whispered punctuation.

Once she was gone, Tirian let out an explosive huff of indignation.

"Wasn't my intention, she says!" she mimicked under her breath, arms flailing in restrained disbelief.

"Let it go, Tirian," Reve places a comforting hand on Tirian's shoulder, "What if she didn't really mean it? Besides," he added, turning to Anteros with a mischievous grin, "It's only natural for someone to be rooting for their own house, right Anteros?"

Anteros only rolled his eyes.

“I hate to admit but Reve is right, Tirian,” he said, offering her a small, understanding smile. “Moon might be a lot of things, but she wasn’t exactly *that* out of line today.”

Well. Except the otiose comment she flung at him after History class. But that was… beside the point.

“Instead of letting that get into us, how about we settle things the proper way?” he continued, folding his arms. “Let’s defeat her statements on the field.”

Tirian paused.

She looked between the two of them—Reve, lounging with the smugness of someone who’d known this would happen, and Anteros, who was already holding out a fist with quiet challenge.

Then, quite suddenly, her expression shifted.

A slow and radiant smile spread across her face, one stitched with mischief and stitched tighter with determination.

“Hmph! As if I’ll let anyone else get the Loom Thread!” Tirian bumped her fists against his, fierce and full of purpose “Well Captain? Ready to vanquish the Moon?”

“You know it.” Anteros replied, his grin tugging wider now.

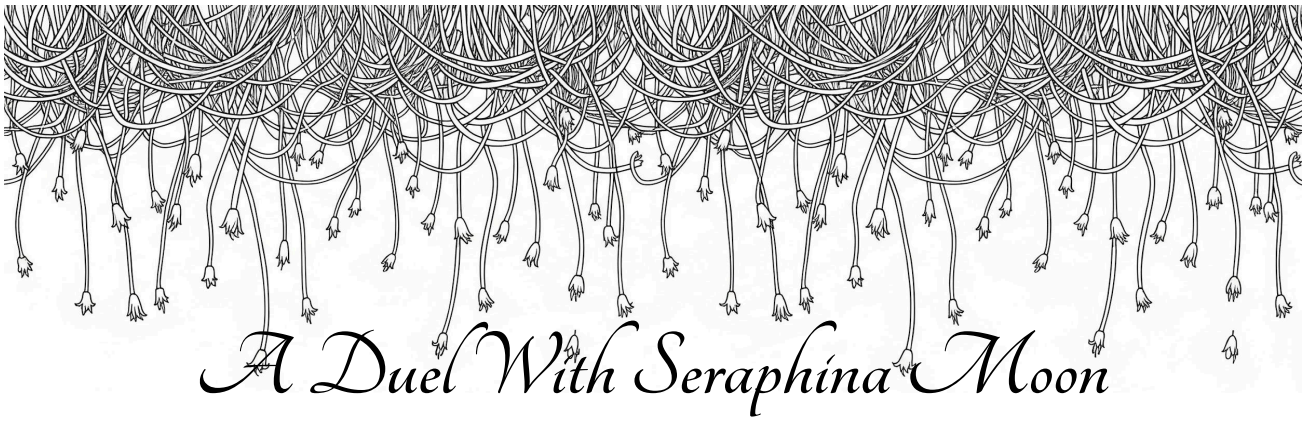
“Can you guys make an exception for Velquinn—”

“No.”

They said in unison.

Reve groaned, hand chest in mock betrayal. “You two are monsters. This is why Aurelyans and Velquinns form underground alliances, you know.”

“And this,” Anteros replied dryly, “is why those alliances never last.”



A Duel With Seraphina Moon

One might think that a grand tournament such as the Sartryx's famed Weaveflight must surely occasion a holiday from scholarly pursuits. Yet, much to the vexation of one Anteros Magnus, the present Headmaster held such a notion in utter contempt.

To suspend the entire day for a mere athletic endeavor?—an event, it might be added, for which the entirety of the Sartryx held its breath in anticipation—Preposterous!

And the sole reason why Anteros Magnus is currently stuck on Desk Twelve once again, sitting beside Seraphina Moon in vexation. However, this time, it wasn't History but Augmenting. Currently, Professor Callagn—the same professor who somehow always arranged it so that Anteros ended up as Moon's deskmate—instructed the class to team up with one's seatmate and stand at the very ends of the room and practice how to duel with their Threadica.

"I want everyone to not cross the line," Professor Callaghn announces, walking around the classroom, a cane in his left hand, tapping the floor as a warning to those who dared to act misconduct. "Mr Sagan, I prefer if you would listen unless you want your thread snapped."

"Yes, Professor." Reve's sulky response earned a giggle from Tirian—who went immediately silent when Callaghn looked at her in warning.

The room fell into a hush.

Even the ever-expressive Reve Sagan had the good sense to zip his lips—though not without throwing Tirian a look that said "worth it."

"Each of you will project your Threadica as a barrier," Callaghn continued, his voice clipped and stern, "and then strike only at your partner's designated quadrant. Control, precision, and restraint. That is the goal."

Anteros Magnus barely stifled a sigh as he turned toward the far wall, where Seraphina Moon already stood, posture regal, fingers twitching as if commanding invisible strings.

Of course she didn't look nervous. She looked like she was the syllabus.

"Mr. Magnus," Professor Callaghn barked. "Do try not to light the curtains on fire again."

"That was one time," Anteros muttered, already bracing himself for the migraine to come.

"Ready, Miss Moon?"

Seraphina's eyes glinted. "Always."

That one word.

That one word, and Anteros suddenly forgot how to thread properly.

He summoned his barrier anyway, a sharp ripple of blue unfolding around him like a dome. Seraphina responded with her own: hers shimmered—shimmered—like woven moonlight, threads so fine they looked like mist.

"Begin!"

The first thread bolt came from her. Swift. Precise. Elegant.

He deflected it with a grunt.

"You're early," he called across the classroom.

"You're slow," she replied.

“Oh, for threads’ sake—”

They stepped to the dueling line.

Two silhouettes beneath the stained-glass dome of the Sartryx dueling chamber, shadows long and tense.

Anteros’ fingers curled. Seraphina raised her hand first—because of course she did.

Their Threads sparked to life.

And—

The duel had begun.

“I said *don’t cross the line*,” Callaghan thundered.

Anteros barely heard him. Mostly because Seraphin Moon had just launched a sequence of thread pulses so fast and sharp they practically sang through the air.

“Are you trying to kill me, Moon?” he snapped, ducking behind his barrier, thread humming with effort.

“If I were,” she replied with an air of coolness and nonchalance, “you’d be on the floor already, Mr. Magnus.”

“How comforting.”

He fired back, a precise strike to knock her off balance—not hurt her—he might think of her unbearable, sure, but not enough to warrant a strike, just rattle her composure a little.

But Seraphina didn’t rattle.

She danced.

Danced.

Like a ballerina stuck in a sonnet.

Moonthread shimmered around her like a cloak of starlight—silent, silver, precise. She pivoted gracefully, letting a blast brush past her shoulder. “Not bad.” she murmured.

“Smug.” he muttered back.

Their threads clashed midair, meeting in a burst of pale purple and dusky blue. Sparks flew. Students gasped. Tirian clapped once—just once—before pretending she hadn’t.

And then—

His birth thread faltered. Axiomae faltered.

Not by a lack of strength, but because Seaphina’s last strike had *curved*. Threads weren’t supposed to curve like that. What was that even called? A crescent thread bolt? A thread that danced mid-air?

“That wasn’t standard Augmenting…” muttered Xoie Troba—bushy-haired, Illustra-ranked, and perpetually looking like she’d walked out of a dandelion field. ”Did she just bend her trajectory? That’s Weaving. Or—Augment-Weft fusion?”

“Whatever it is, Moon is gonna win,” gloated Mika Ella, resplendent in Aurelya silver. “That means a win for us.”

“Ugh.” Shayne Limerence groaned from a nearby desk, “This doesn’t even count.”

No one taught crescent arcs in standard Threadica drills. That was advanced—bordering on instinctive. Bordering on innate.

Seraphina Moon didn’t give him any chance of breathing room.

His barrier flickered. Just slightly.

She saw it.

She lunged.

A final thread of *light*. Blinding, sharp, and dangerously fast that Anteros thought he was to be sliced clean off his head. It sent him back, his boots catching on the polished tile, balance teetering—

He was going to fall.

Except he didn't.

Because Seraphina—Seraphina Moon—had moved.

A glowing hand caught his sleeve.

Her fingers were warm. Too warm. Like the thread still lived in them.

She caught him. Seraphin Moon caught him.

He didn't know what felt more dangerous—her strike or her hand.

"...Apologies." she murmured, her hand lingering upon his sleeve, a gesture which, for its unexpectedness, did perhaps discompose him more than the near-fall itself, "I did not intend to—"

"Such a wonderful display of Threadica Miss Moon." Professor Callaghn interrupted, clapping precisely once, as if applause could be rationed like ink. "Impressive. That move is not in the syllabus. Not in any syllabus."

Seraphina dropped her hand.

Anteros forgot how to breathe.

Did Seraphina Moon just… apologized to him?

Anteros wasn't sure what stunned him more—the duel or the apology.

He wasn't used to Seraphina Moon saying sorry. He wasn't used to Seraphina Moon *catching* him, either. Frankly, he wasn't used to Seraphina Moon looking at him other than disdain. Especially not with her annoying, irritating, unfairly luminous purple eyes.

(They weren't even just purple. They were the exact color of royal ink. Or betrayal. Or poisoned perfume.)

He opened his mouth to say something—anything—but she had already turned away, the hem of her uniform billowing like a curtain closing in on a scene he hadn't rehearsed for.

Professor Callaghn dismissed the class with an audible thump of his cane, the sound final as a period. "Out, all of you. And no flaming corridors this time."

The room buzzed back to life. Desks scraped. Thread flickered back to dormancy. Students scattered like startled moths after a too-bright duel.

Some were prancing around with documents and folders—color-coded, ribbon-bound, overly officious. Among them was, naturally, Seraphina Moon. Managerial duties, he guessed. She probably has written down his weaknesses from the duel in bullet points and subcategories. Maybe even footnotes,

"... What," he muttered to no one, "just happened?"

From the sidelines, Reve—who was now sporting a burnt fringe (Hah, now he really embodied burnt orange)—made a strangled sort of wheeze that might have aspired once to be a whistle.

"You got saved, Romeo," he grinned, elbowing Anteros with all the force of a small avalanche. "By *her*. I can't wait to tell Eliana."

``Eliana Sagan? Why the heck would you tell your sister?"

"She deserves to *know*."

Tirian said nothing. She simply offered a polite smile—pulling off her slightly burnt gloves with precise, even movements. Folded them. Tucked into her coat pocket. Her smile was faint. Controlled. And just sharp enough to make him wince.

"We should prepare, Captain," she says with clipped formality, "Weaveflight starts at 5." And with that, she turned and walked off, not sparing either of them another glance.

Anteros turned to Reve, who only shrugged. They then followed Tirian's steps—less because they had to, more because that's what captains did.

Outside, the skies above the Sartryx shimmered with gold-threaded clouds. Banners flapped. Trumpets cried. Somewhere, someone was already late.

The Weaveflight Arena had been conjured from the threads older than the Sartryx itself—woven from high Threadica and higher ego. Floating staircases led up to it like a procession of vanity. And at the center of it all, suspended like a crown of sting, was the Loom Thread.

Anteros stared at it from his team's prep tent, arms crossed, jaw tight.

"You know," Reve said beside him, tugging his half-burnt sleeve, "for a guy who nearly got obliterated in class earlier, you're remarkably composed."

"I'm not thinking about that," Anteros lied.

"Sure you aren't," Reve said, grinning. "You've been staring at the Loom Thread like it insulted your bloodline."

Which, to be fair, it had.

Somewhat.

It was bad enough that Seraphina Moon now had bragging rights. It was worse that she'd apologize. But the worst part—the part that he could not forgive—was that he'd let her catch him.

Ugh,

"Why are you even still here, Sagan?" Anteros rubbed his temples, "This is the Illustra Tent."

"You guys have snacks." Reve replies, slightly grumbling. "Velquinns don't. How unfair is that!"

"Captain Magnus!" a voice chirped—Xoie, clipboard in hand, a dandelion hurricane of nerves. "We're up at fifteen! Tirian's checking the quadrant allocations and—oh, Shayne's having a pre-match breakdown in the bathroom again."

Of course he was.

“Tell him he has five minutes to emotionally recover,” Anteros said flatly, “and three to warm up.”

Reve was already half-laughing. “You’re gonna snap a thread at this rate.”

He might. Especially if Seraphina Moon showed up again looking unbothered and luminous and somehow terrifying in that Aurely silver.

“Your manager is calling for you, Reve.” Tirian interrupts, emerging from the outside. “She said, ‘Stop hogging all the snacks and come back already!’” Her voice lilt, roughly shoving Reve—who protested the whole way— out of the tent.

The jingle of bells echoed throughout the arena, signaling the start of the Weaveflight. Multitudes of glowing threads unraveled from the sky itself—long ribbons cascading like divine embroidery, weaving across the air in looping patterns, The sky pulsed with enchantment, alive with the cheers of students whose voices stitched the very magic of the field. Banners shimmered. The Loom Thread spiraled.

From their prep tent, Anteros could feel the thrum beneath his ribs. Axiomae was responding.

From the raised manager’s tier, Seraphina Moon stood like a stitched commandment—clipboard in hand, expression unreadable, Aurelya’s silver banners rustled behind her. Her silver scarf, tied precisely at her throat, remained perfectly still despite the wind.

She wasn’t flying, not really. Merely a manager, not a player. But she may as well have been. Her gaze followed him like a second tail.

The arena shifted.

“Focus, Captain,” Tirian muttered beside him, already tightening the straps of her Tail. “Don’t let the Moon distract you.”

“I’m not distracted.” Anteros said.

“Of course,” she said—eyebrows furrowed in contempt. “And I’m a Threadling.”

Spools unfurled in midair, hovering like thorns or traps—he couldn't yet tell. Thread rings, as fine as spider silk and twice dangerous, rotated on invisible axes. Somewhere above, the Fate Ring glowed like a moon caught in netting.

This was no field.

This was a battleground dressed in beauty.

Tirian inhaled sharply beside him, her scarf fluttering in pre-flight alignment, eyes narrowed and jaw set. "Team Illustra. Ready?"

Anteros drew a breath. "We were born ready."

The crowd roared.

And then—they leapt.

Four streaks of color tore into the sky, Tails unfurling like banners of war, thread tails crackling behind them. Aurelya. Velquinn. Ilustra. Therynox. Rivalry took flight. The Stray Thread shimmered once—twice—then bolted the arena like a living comet.

Moonlight watched.

And the chase began.

Weaveflight with Manager Moon

In hindsight, everything was going well so far for Illustra.

Anteros Magnus had successfully warded at least five potential scores from Aurelyan Tailweavers—a feat that would've earned him three fist-bumps, two glittering scrolls, and perhaps a statue if Reve were the judge. His teammates were in sync. Tirian had landed a double-threaded sweep. Shayne had only panicked once. Even the air seemed to favor them—cool, crisp, thrumming with momentum.

Which was why the numbers didn't make sense.

Illustra: 45

Aurelya: 52.

Anteros blinked at the scoreboard, half-suspended in midair, Axiomae fluttering beneath him like a loyal sash on the verge of outrage.

That couldn't be right.

It had been 45 to 40 before the timeout. Aurelya had barely scored. The only change during the break was a brief, hushed meeting between their players and–of course—Seraphina Moon.

Manager Moon, to be precise. Who had, in her infinite composure and clipboard-wielding wisdom, called the timeout with all the dignity of a war general halting a siege. She hadn't raised her voice. She hadn't even moved much. Just whispered a few words to her team with one hand on her silver scarf, and somehow—*somehow*—the sky itself had tilted in their favor.

“What in the threads—” Anteros muttered.

“Oi, Captain,” Tirian’s voice came sharp through the comm thread crackling in his ear. “Tell me I’m not hallucinating.”

“You’re not,” he replied. “We were winning.”

“Exactly,” she snapped. “So why the hell does it look like Moon just rewrote the scoreboard by *talking*.”

“..Um, maybe it’s manager privilege?” Jane Lawrence, Illustra’s Unraveler nervously offers a smile. “Maybe—maybe she flirted with fate?”

Anteros grits his teeth. “Get serious.”

"Aurelya's gotten too good at dodging my attacks," she sighed, rubbing her nose with a sniff. "They seem to really target my left flank."

"Your left flank?" Tirian growled, her voice laced with concern. "That's where you were injured last week. They're using it as an advantage!" She whirled to face Anteros, eyes blazing with conviction. "Captain, this isn't right. We need to file a dispute."

“No time,” Anteros said grimly. Because below them, the Stray Thread had started moving again. Faster now. Almost like it was… running.

“Troba, Limerence—thread the open gaps” Anteros shifted his Tail, snapping it into alignment, “I’ll ward. Lawrence—guard your left, strike with your right. Tirian, catch the Stray Thread. Fast.”

“Aye Captain!”

The sky cracked open in a roar of color and cheers.

“AND IT’S AURELYA WITH AN EARLY ADVANCE—tail threads twisting like firecrackers!” the announcer’s voice boomed across the arena, magic-thread amplified and emotionally biased. “We’ve got Mika Ella dodging a double spin from Troba—what a maneuver!”

Anteros Magnus gritted his teeth, eyes locked on the flickering shimmer on the Stray Thread as it zipped past his left flank like a mischievous comet.

"Axiomae," he murmured, and his Tail surged beneath him.

"Magnus dives!" the commentator shouted, "Will Illustra reclaim control before Aurelya loops again? It's Magnus versus Cahir, the terrifying Wardens! Is Aurelya gonna maintain its trajectory?"

Not if I can help it, Anteros thought grimly.
He veered across a sweeping Tailweaver from Aurelya—Osyth Anore, sharp and smug. Threads sparked between them, brief and blue, before Axiomae clean through a wave illusion and realigned to intercept the Thread.

Below him, Tirian shot forward like a needle through silk.
"Thread! Now!" she barked through the comms.

"ON IT!" he shouted, slamming his palm forward, calling the warding lines into shape. His barrier hummed—solid and unbreakable—as the Stray Thread looped toward their quadrant.

It flickered once. Twice.

And then—BOOM!

It bounced off his ward, spiraling back toward the center.

"OH, WHAT A BLOCK FROM MAGNUS!" the announce crowed. "And Illustra's Captain holds the line like a stitched savior! Aurelya's denied!"

The crowd screamed. Somewhere above the noise, a banner unraveled midair—**GO ILLUSTRA OR GO HOME.**

Anteros didn't smile. He didn't have the luxury.

From the opposite sky-side, Seraphina Moon stood as ever—expression unreadable, clipboard in hand. She tapped her stylus once. Just once.

Immediately, Aurelya's formation shifted.

“They’re changing thread alignment!” Tirian shouted. “Left flank loop approach!”

“On your six,” muttered Jane, “I’ll unravel their tail weave.”

“Go,” Anteros ordered. “Break them.”

“AND AURELYA’S BACK ON THE OFFENSIVE!” the commentator gasped. “A new formation! Threads blazing! Did Seraphina Moon just call an off-script maneuver?! You bet she did!”

Of course she did.

Of course she did.

Because Seraphina Moon didn’t need to fly to control the sky.

She simply whispered—and the stars obeyed.

Anteros adjusted his stance, threads humming under his boots.

Let’s see how well the Moon flies when the Sun is ready to burn.

Jane Lawrence, like a bull charging a red cloth, fiercely bulldozed through the approaching offenses of Aurelya's fleet against the Stray Thread. Across the sky, Eiran Anore cursed into oblivion as his Tail tangled mid-dive, a chaotic mess of thread and pride.

“Captain!” Shayne Limerence’s voice crackled through the comm, breathless and thrilled. “We cleared a path—Lawrence’s… tactic worked! The Stray Thread’s heading our way!”

“Good job, you two!” Anteros called, already steering Axiomae into position. “Tirian, you ready?”

“Yup!” Tirian grinned, Ignara humming in bright pink splendor beneath her. “Just say the word!”

“NOW!”

Like twin comets, they tore through the sky—Anteros shielding her flank with expert wards, Tirian weaving forward with all the grace of a trained sky-striker. Her Tail danced through rings and spools, narrowly avoiding an Aurelyan rebound.

Every second sparked like thread on the verge of snapping.

Tirian's fingers were *inches* from the Stray Thread.

It shimmered before her—taunting, pulsing, nearly caught. Ignara surged beneath her like a ribbon of pink light. One more second and—

"Going somewhere, sweetheart?"

A hand shot out.

Not thread. Not magic. Just *hair*.

Luan Cahir—Aurelya's smug excuse of a Warden—had the gall to *grab her by the braid*, tugging just enough to throw her off-balance.

Tirian let out a shriek that was half outrage, half war cry.

"LET GO, YOU ABSOLUTE THREAD-LEECH—!"

"Oops," Luan sang, already darting forward, "didn't see your altitude. Tragic."

"Tirian!" Anteros shouted, fury slicing through his focus. No time to think. No time to curse. He veered sharply, rerouting his flight.

Binder. He has to be the Binder.

He dove.

Axiomae responded instantly, tail twisting like a live wire, aiming him toward the still-drifting Stray Thread.

"Almost there—" he muttered.

The sky pulsed.

The thread glowed.

It leaned towards his palm.

And then—

Gone.

No—not vanished. *Taken.*

A shape slipped from above. Silent. Masked. Wrapped in a cloak threaded in shadows. One hand outstretched. No Tail. No team colors. No hesitation.

They moved like they'd always been there. Like they belonged there,

And in a single motion—*caught the Stray Thread.*

Dead silence rippled through the crowd.

The announcer's voice crackled. Hesitated. Then, nothing.

The masked figure lingered midair, head turning—not to the referees—but to *Seraphina Moon* in the manager's tier.

A beat passed.

Then another.

And just as the arena seemed to find its breath again—the sky fractured beneath them.

"MOON!"

Anteros didn't think. He moved.

The sky behind the masked figure shattered—a rippling tear of silver and ink splitting through the clouds like glass under strain. The sound was wrong. Not thunder. Not magic. A low, dragging noise, like fate being unzipped.

And it cracked open right beneath Seraphina Moon.

She didn't scream.

She never screamed.

But her footing faltered atop the manager's tier, clipboard clattering to the side as the threads beneath her shimmered unstable—distorted—like warped reflections on a broken loom.

"Seraphina!"

Anteros dove, Axiomae burning bright behind him in streaks of blue and gold. The wind howled past his ears. Threads of the fractured sky snaked upward like hungry tendrils.

She was falling.

No time. No plan. Just instinct and terror and something he hadn't named yet.

He reached out.

Fingers outstretched.

She turned in the air—calm, almost resigned—as if she'd known this was coming.

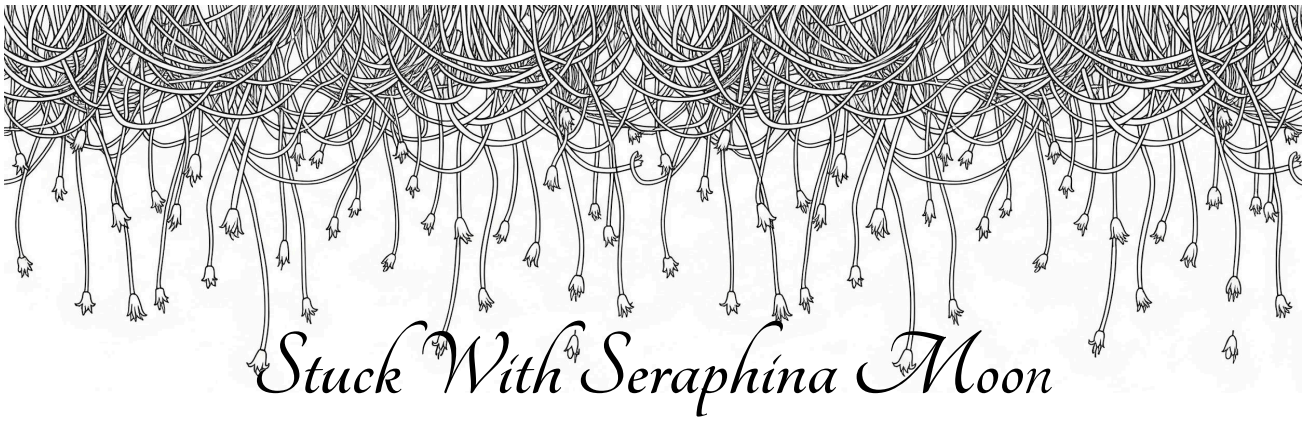
Their hands met mid-plummet.

Anteros' breath caught—

Not because he saved her.

But because at that moment, she let him.

And the world snapped.



Stuck With Seraphina Moon

This is the first time Anteros Magnus was in a Thread Fracture.

It was *so wrong*.

Not in the flashy, dramatic way professors warned about—no flames or lightning, no thunder that ruptured the world. Like walking into a room you'd lived in all your life, only to find the furniture rearranged and the clocks ticking backward.

It was *dark*, but not the kind of dark that simply lacked light. This was a kind of darkness that remembered light and resented it. Threads shimmered faintly around him like the afterimage of stars—frayed, ghostlike—suspended in space where nothing moved, yet everything breathed.

Time stuttered. Sound was a memory.

Axiomae trembled under his grasp.—still there, but blurred, severed in places, like a bad splice. It felt wrong against his palm, like the connection skipping like a missed heartbeat.

"Seraphina?" he called out—but the name fell flat, sucked into the space a voice underwater. "Moon, if you're still there, please just—say something." A pause, then softer: "Even if it's to tell me to shut up."

Silence.

Not even an echo. Just the kind of silence that pressed his ears like spun thread, too soft, too smothering. Even his own breath felt like a stranger.

The air (was it air?) felt *thick*. Like grief. Like guilt. Like a bad decision.

Where is Seraphina Moon?

He remembered taking her hand as they fell. That unnerving coolness against his skin—like her name made it tangible.

"Moon," he tried again, this time quieter. More like a wish than a call. "I know you don't like to talk with someone beneath you. I know you're good at that. I know you—"

Something grabbed his leg.

The world turned upside down.

Literally.

A violent jolt yanked him downward—no, sideways—no, in every direction at once. Threadlines snapped past him like whips. Colors smeared like wet ink. His ears rang. Axiomae sputtered, threads flickering wild and unformed, unable to stabilize.

His vision twisted.

The fracture was slowly piercing itself together.

Shapes bled into the space—like shadows caught between weaves. Half-faces. Half-threads. Hands that didn't end in fingers. Things might have once been people, now stretched too thin, unraveled by time and magic and something crueler.

And in the middle of it—

"Seraphina—!"

There she was.

Suspended midair like a forgotten marionette, body limp but glowing faintly, as if fate hadn't quite decided what to do with her yet. Threads wrapped around her—not restraining, but *holding*, like the remnants of a loom trying to remember how to weave.

Beside her was—

"You!"

The same masked figure.

The one who had no Tail;, no team, no name—only silence and certainty. The same one who took the Stray Thread like he'd owned it.

His hand was on her thread.

Not just touching. *Holding.* Cradling it like something precious and breakable and *his.*

Anteros' breath caught. The thread pulsing from Seraphina's chest was the color of blue—*yes*, her blue—but laced now with gold. *Gold.* Not even Aurelya silver. Not moonlight. The color of the Sun.

It can't be.

Seraphina Moon, born of moonlight—Moon—and yet…

There it was. Gold. Threaded through her like a secret trying to become a truth.

"Why are you so stubborn?" the masked figure hissed, voice low and hoarse with fury. "This power is mine. I will take it."

He gripped the thread tighter. The gold within it flared—violent, radiant—as though the very concept of being *taken* offended it.

And it fought.

The glow pulsed wildly now, pushing against the intruder's hand like a heart refusing to surrender. Sparks burst from the thread—wild, brilliant, *alive*.

The masked figure flinched. Just slightly. But enough.

"Preastres," he rasped. "Come to me."

Preastres.

The word hung there.

Heavy. Reverent. Desperate.

And then, quieter:

"*Please*." he whispered, like a child calling to a lost dream.

And then, impatient:

"**NOW**!"

The threads tightened around Seraphina, dragging taut at her ches, her shoulders—Her eyebrows twitched. A small furrow between them. Pain, perhaps. Resistance.

She's still in there, Anteros realized.

And then he moved.

He didn't think.

Didn't plan.

Didn't hesitate.

Just *lunged.*

"GET AWAY FROM HER!"

But he was too slow.

The masked figure turned. No panic. No startle. Just inevitability, cloaked in calm.

And yet—something shifted.

He raised a hand.

And Axiomae—his thread—hesitated.

Only for a breath.

But it was there.

It wavered under Anteros' grip—not in fear, but in recognition.

"What..?"

But the question didn't finish.

"Always too slow." the masked figure said.

And he struck.

Pain bloomed sharp and searing in Anteros' stomach—because it wasn't just a strike.

It was Axiomae.

His own *birth thread.*

Driven through him.

"Mhm!"

Anteros looked up—blinking through the pain blooming in his stomach, his vision flickering between threadlight and shadow.

And there she was.

Seraphina Moon.
Awake.
Fighting against threads coiling around her like a serpent from a broken loom. Her breath was ragged; her perfect mask was gone, her brow furrowed into something dangerously close to worry.

Her thread pulsed erratically **blue laced with gold**, stammering like a heartbeat caught between two fates,

"M— Mr. Magnus," she choked, voice uneven. Not cold. Not clipped. ***Real.***

He almost laughed—because of course she'd call him *formally* in a situation like this.

The masked figure seemed to flinch. Turned. his head tilted—not in triumph, but in something like… reverence. Or regret.

"You shouldn't be awake yet," he said. Quiet. Chiding. Almost *fond.*

Seraphina's gaze snapped at him.
"Don't—touch—him!" she hissed.

Her thread burned brighter—blue and gold flaring against the shadows binding her, nearly searing through them.

Anteros' eyes widened.
Seraphina Moon… worried?
About him?
That Seraphina Moon?

"No. Don't," the masked figure shrilled, Axiomae slipping free of his control, "**THAT POWER IS NOT YOURS TO BEAR**!"

The thread in his hand sparked violently, resisting his hold.

Anteros didn' t wait.
He lunged—Axiomae flaring to life in his grip, fingers wrapping around the hilt of what was—what *should* have always been—his.

He pulled.

"AGH!"

A deep slash of pain tore through the masked man's side.

Red—no, gold—unwound from him like thread torn from a tapestry, blooming into the air in a violent shimmering spray.

The masked figure staggered, threads hissing around him and coiling around him in retreat. The Fracture itself seemed to shudder.

And then—
he **was gone.**

Like a skipped stitch.
Like a name forgotten mid-sentence.

A burning pain consumed Anteros's stomach, bringing him to his knees. Cold hands gripped his frame, steadying him amidst the sounds of shifting and heavy breathing.

"Mr—Magnus, " her voice caught, ragged—"are you hurt?" Seraphina Moon's voice, thick with panic and concern, reached him. He wondered if this was all a nightmare—a consequence of a mid-Weaveflight collision that had knocked him unconscious. Yet, the searing pain was undeniable; Axiomae had indeed stabbed him. And Seraphina Moon was actually *helping* him.

"Try to stay awake—I'll—I'll find a way out!"

Anteros was surprised that Moon, a head shorter and more lithe, had enough strength to stabilize him. Her figure wasn't suited for Weavflight, but then again, she *had* beaten him in a duel earlier.

Seraphina Moon's hands were slick with gold. Not hers, not entirely. Anteros could feel his own thread pulsed—weakly, as if Axiomae doesn't know whether to stabilize or shatter.

She stumbled forward through the Fracture, breath ragged, her uniform torn at the shoulder. The perfection is gone.
Only the girl remained.

And still—still—her grip was steady.

"...Moon, you—" he gasped, pain flaring white—hot in his abdomen, "You bear… Preastres?"

She doesn't meet his gaze.
Her lips trembled.
Her fingers tightened around his.

"I… I don't know."

The words felt wrong in her mouth.
Uncharacteristic.
Un-Moonlike.
Unvain.

Seraphina Moon—who had an answer ready, always, even way before professors could utter a single word said;

"*I don't know.*"

Her voice breaks open like a thread snapping under pressure. And she keeps walking.

Preastres.
A word uttered only with reverence—never casually, never without consequence.

He'd heard it once during Codex class.
The most powerful Thread in all of Fatum; not mere magic, not ordinary weave. A seal. A burden. A covenant older than the Sartryx itself.

Only those touched by gods—or marked by fate as more than mortal—could ever hope to bear it.

One bearer rises with each generation. Chosen not by talent or lineage, but by resonance.

He remembered the exact day Professor Ruedan said it—chalk dust hanging in the air, Tirian half-asleep, Reve doodling in his palm. And Seraphina Moon? *Late*, with some excuse about "dogs" and "baths".

But he remembered most:
The last known bearer lived *hundreds of generations ago*, in the Age of Eclipse, when the Oraisayn turned upside down and the Loom of Fate burned itself to ash

So why—after a thousand years of stillness—
Was it burning now, inside Seraphina Moon's thread?

Seraphina—who stumbled under his weight—walks in furrowed brows and grim steadiness through the darkness of the Fracture.

“Moon—” it was the only thing he trusted himself to say after being stabbed with his own thread by a man in a ridiculous mask— “please tell me you know where we’re going.”

Seraphina looked at him from beneath her silver-white fringe, those violet, iridescent eyes locking onto his green half-lidded ones.

“No.” she said.

Ah. Vain as always, even with a worried brow and an injured man on her side.

Still, Anteros couldn't blame her *this time*.

No one really knew what to do in a Thread Fracture.

The only ones they knew lived in textbooks and Codex exams.

Never the real thing.

“Mr. Magnus—” she breathes, golden flecks flickering around like starlight in ink, “Even if you’d rather not speak to me… keep talking. Anything. Just—don’t stop.”

Anteros flinches at the sound of it—vulnerability, raw and trembling, laced in Seraphina’s usual glacial tone.

“Do not close your eyes.” She says, voice thin, “I—I will try to find a way out of this Fracture.”

As the words came out of her mouth, the air shimmered—blue and gold blooming faintly in the darkness.

Seraphina Moon trembled.
Under his weight. Under the thread. Under the pressure of it all.
Sweat beads at her brows now. But she doesn’t stop walking.

"...Why do you say that?"
Her head tilts, as if she didn't quite hear him over the low hum of the Fracture.

"What?"

"That—" he gulps, breath hitching as another wave of pain claws through his ribs, "That I don't want to talk to you."

The sound between them changes—less the ruch of torn threads, more the sharp pause of an unpicked stitch.
Seraphina goes silent for a beat too long.

"... Don't most Sartryx avoid each other?" she says too quickly, the words almost trapping over each other.
"And… I'm an Aurelyan, you're an Ilustra. And besides that…"

Her breath catches. His weight shifts suddenly—unexpected, heavy—and she grabs him without thinking, her fingers curling in the fabric at his shoulder.
"Sorry—!"

The air ripples faintly around them, threads stretching thin, as if even the Fracture were leaning to listen.

"I'm Seraphina Moon," she says. Soft. Final. Like a reason and an apology and a resignation, all at once.

Her name hung between them, heavier than it should have been.

It should have sounded like the thousand times he'd heard it before—rolled form other people's tongues in admiration, in gossip, in complaint. But from her own lips… it landed different.

He wanted to argue. He wanted to tell her it wasn't an answer. But his voice wouldn't obey—not with her looking at him like that, steady despite strain, her fingers anchored in his shoulder.

It was ridiculous.
This was still the Seraphina Moon. The one who moved through the Sartryx

as if every corridor bent toward her. The one who always had a sharper reply than he did. The one whose name came with rumors than truth.

And yet—

He found himself watching the faint tremor in her hands, the way her breathing hitched only after she was sure he was upright.

Infuriating,

"...You really think that explains anything?" he muttered, forcing the edge back into his voice.

Her eyes—violet, bright even in the Fracture's dim glow—didn't flinch. "No. But it's all I'm giving right now."

The corner of his mouth almost twitched upward. Almost. "Figures."

Still, when she started forward again, he didn't let go of her hand.
And when she didn't pull away, he pretended not to notice.

They walked in silence for what could have been minutes, or years—time bent strange here. The darkness pressed closer with every step, thick with the quiet of something holding its breath.

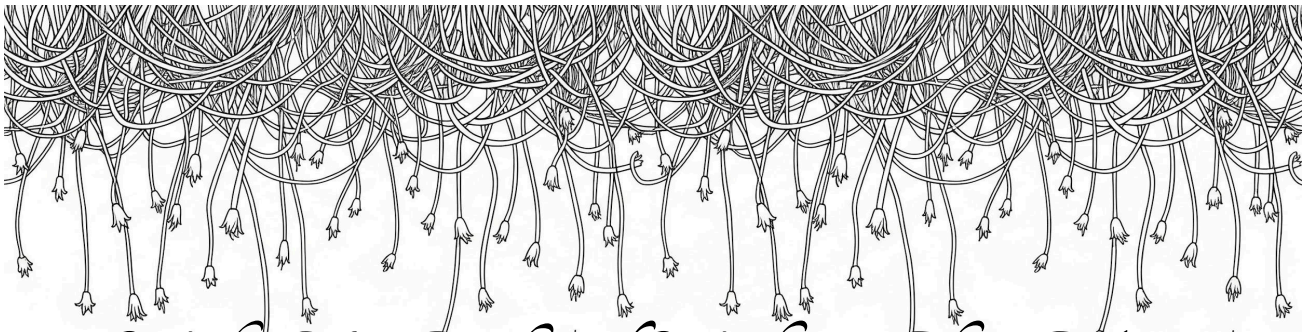
Somewhere ahead, the threads shifted. Not from their movement.
From something else.
A ripple passed through the weave—deliberate, like a finger tracing silk.

Anteros' grip tightened around her hand without thought.
"Moon," he murmured.

She didn't answer.

Then, from the dark, came the sound.
Not footsteps. Not breathing.
A low, deliberate snip.

The kind that unmade.



Woke Up Confused Without The Moon

Anteros woke up to a golden ceiling and white walls. Warmth, not the ones the Iluytri usually weaves, but a feeling of hands enveloping his own and strands of pink hair leaving his chest and meeting concerned blue eyes.

“Anteros!” He hears Tirian’s gentle voice call out to the nurse and footsteps scattering. He feels several figures surrounding him like a pack of hounds.